

GREASE

IS THE WORD

★ ★ ★ Exploring the 1950s, 
Post-War Optimism,
and the *Ultimate Rock-*
and-Roll Phenomenon ★ ★ ★ 

Cruisin' into the Past!

Post-War Optimism:



A booming US economy gave families unprecedented disposable income, creating a culture of leisure and consumption.



Car Culture & Independence:

Automobiles gave youth the freedom to socialize at drive-in movies and diners, away from adult supervision.



Birth of Rock-and-Roll:



A rebellious new genre defined teenage identity, distinct from their parents' generation.



The Rydell Reality: Grease is not a historical documentary. It is a 1978 fairytale reflecting a 1970s nostalgia for a "simpler" 1950s.

The 1971 Chicago Stage Play

Created by Jim Jacobs and Warren Casey.
Based on real urban high schools.

The original script was raunchy,
rough, and rooted in authentic
working-class teenage angst.

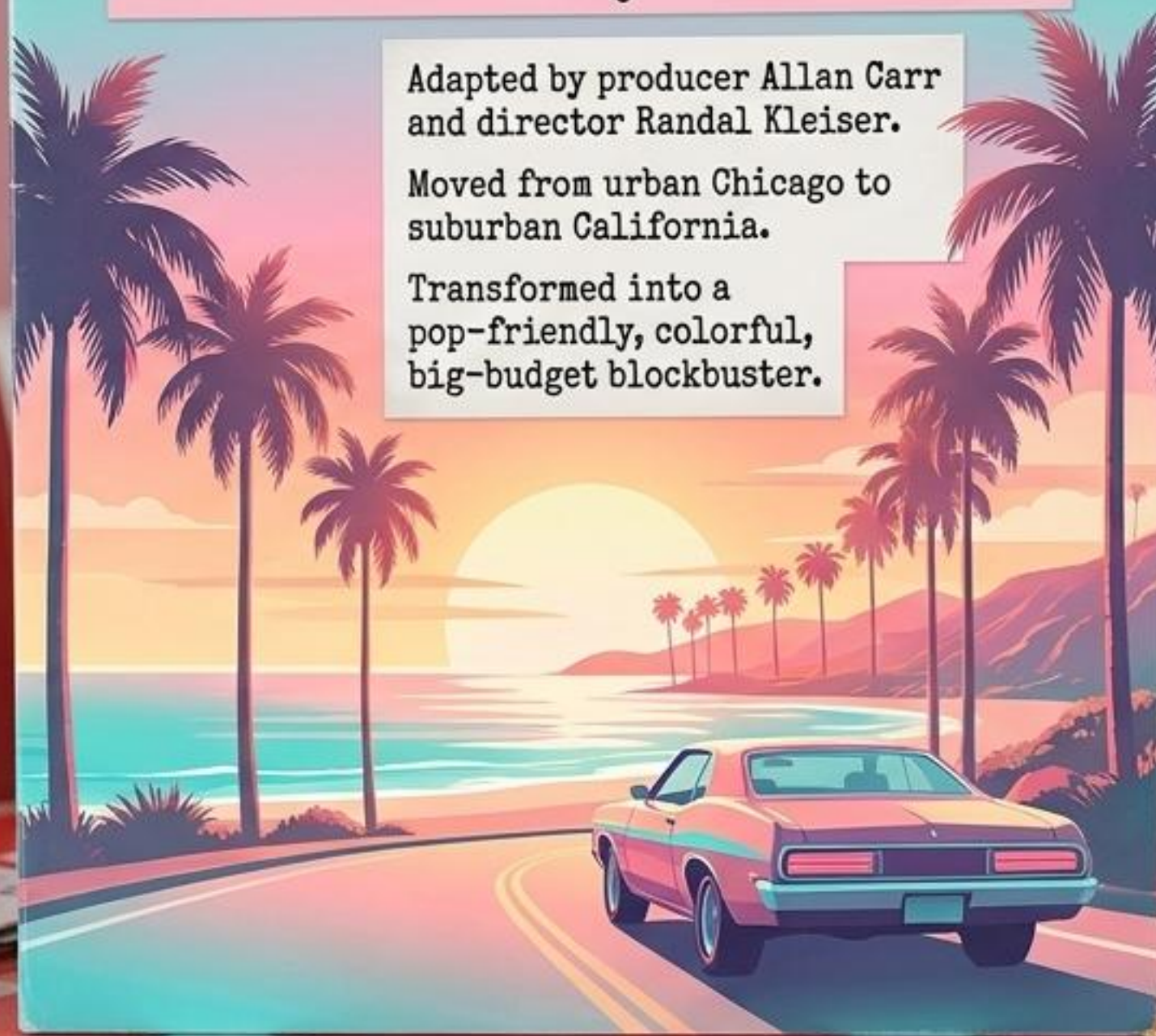


The 1978 Hollywood Movie

Adapted by producer Allan Carr
and director Randal Kleiser.

Moved from urban Chicago to
suburban California.

Transformed into a
pop-friendly, colorful,
big-budget blockbuster.





*Danny Zuko: Henry Winkler.
Turned down the role fearing he
would be typecast as a greaser.
John Travolta took the lead.*



*Sandy Olsson: Carrie Fisher.
Strongly considered for the role. Olivia
Newton-John demanded a screen test
due to lack of acting experience and won.*



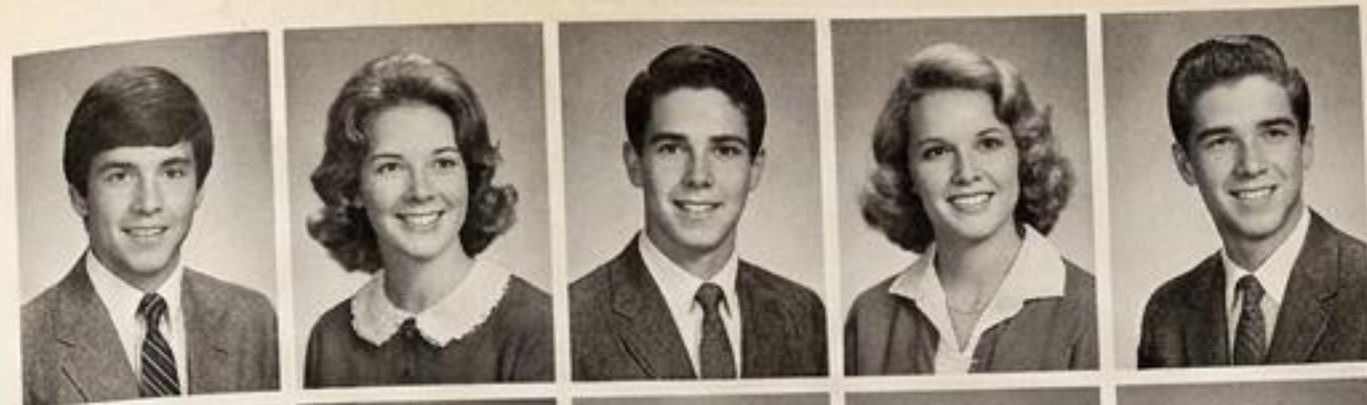
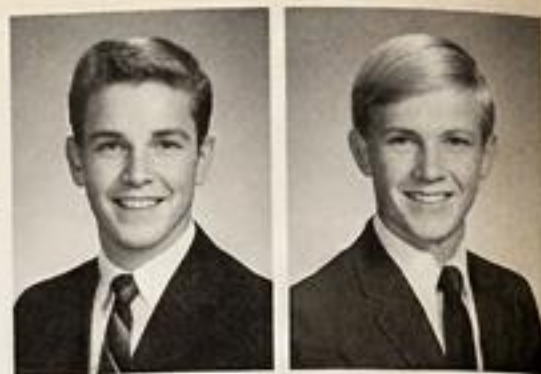
*Rizzo: Lucie Arnaz.
Lucille Ball's daughter lost the role
due to contract issues, opening the
door for Stockard Channing.*



*Teen Angel: Elvis Presley.
The King of Rock and Roll was
considered but passed away before
filming. Frankie Avalon took the part.*

The Casting Rule:

Director Randal Kleiser used the crow's feet test. As long as actors didn't have visible wrinkles around their eyes, they could play high schoolers.



The 33-Year-Old Teenagers

The Reality:

Stockard Channing (Rizzo) was 33. Didi Conn (Frenchy) was 27. Olivia Newton-John was 29.

The Effect:

The older cast gave the actors a license to be goofy, crazy, and horny, elevating the movie from a teen drama to a heightened, confident musical fantasy.

Today's Specials:
The Rydell High Ecosystem

	<i>The T-Birds</i>	<i>The Pink Ladies</i>
<i>Uniform & Style</i>	Leather jackets, slicked-back hair, white T-shirts.	Pastel pink satin jackets, poodle skirts, cat-eye glasses.
<i>Vibe & Attitude</i>	Tough facade, car-obsessed, outwardly rebellious but secretly vulnerable.	Sarcastic, rule-bending, navigating the double standards of teen romance.
<i>Ultimate Mission</i>	Restoring the Greased Lightnin' car to win a drag race at Thunder Road.	Navigating identity, peer pressure, and high school social hierarchy.
<i>The Icons</i>	Danny Zuko & Kenickie	Betty Rizzo & Frenchy

Anatomy of Style

Look 1: The Conformist

White Mary Janes:
Symbolizes
innocence, strict
societal rules, and
1950s suburban
conformity.



Look 2: The Rebel Chic

**Vintage Sharkskin
Pants:** Symbolizes
empowerment and
breaking social norms.



No Room For Error:

The pants were genuine 1950s vintage. Because the zipper was broken, Olivia Newton-John had to be physically sewn into them every morning!

YOU'RE THE ONE THAT I WANT:
A last-minute addition. The cast had to lip-synch lines they barely knew, and the choreography was invented on the spot.

HOPELESSLY DEVOTED TO YOU:
This ballad wasn't even written until the movie was halfway done. It was filmed after principal photography wrapped and earned an Oscar nomination.

GREASED LIGHTNIN':
Originally written for the character Kenickie. John Travolta used his newfound star power to take the song for Danny Zuko instead.

GREASE (TITLE TRACK):
Written by Barry Gibb and sung by Frankie Valli. The producers initially considered having The Beach Boys sing it.

Behind the Scenes Trivia

The Heatwave



Filming the carnival finale took place on a scorching football field with no shade, leading to rampant heat exhaustion and dehydration among the cast.

The Soda Wars



A product placement deal with Pepsi meant expensive expensive optical blurs had to be added in post-production to hide the Coca-Cola signs covering the diner set.

The Summer Party



The shoot was a summer-long party. The T-Birds actors even got stranded on a sailboat during a break and barely made it back to set in time for a night shoot.

Cultural Impact By The Numbers



SCORE

\$396+
Million

The highest-grossing movie musical of the 20th century, eclipsing *The Sound of Music*.

SCORE

#2 Album
of 1978

The soundtrack was the second best-selling album of the year, beaten only by *Saturday Night Fever*.

SCORE

4
Awards

Won every People's Choice Award category it was nominated in.

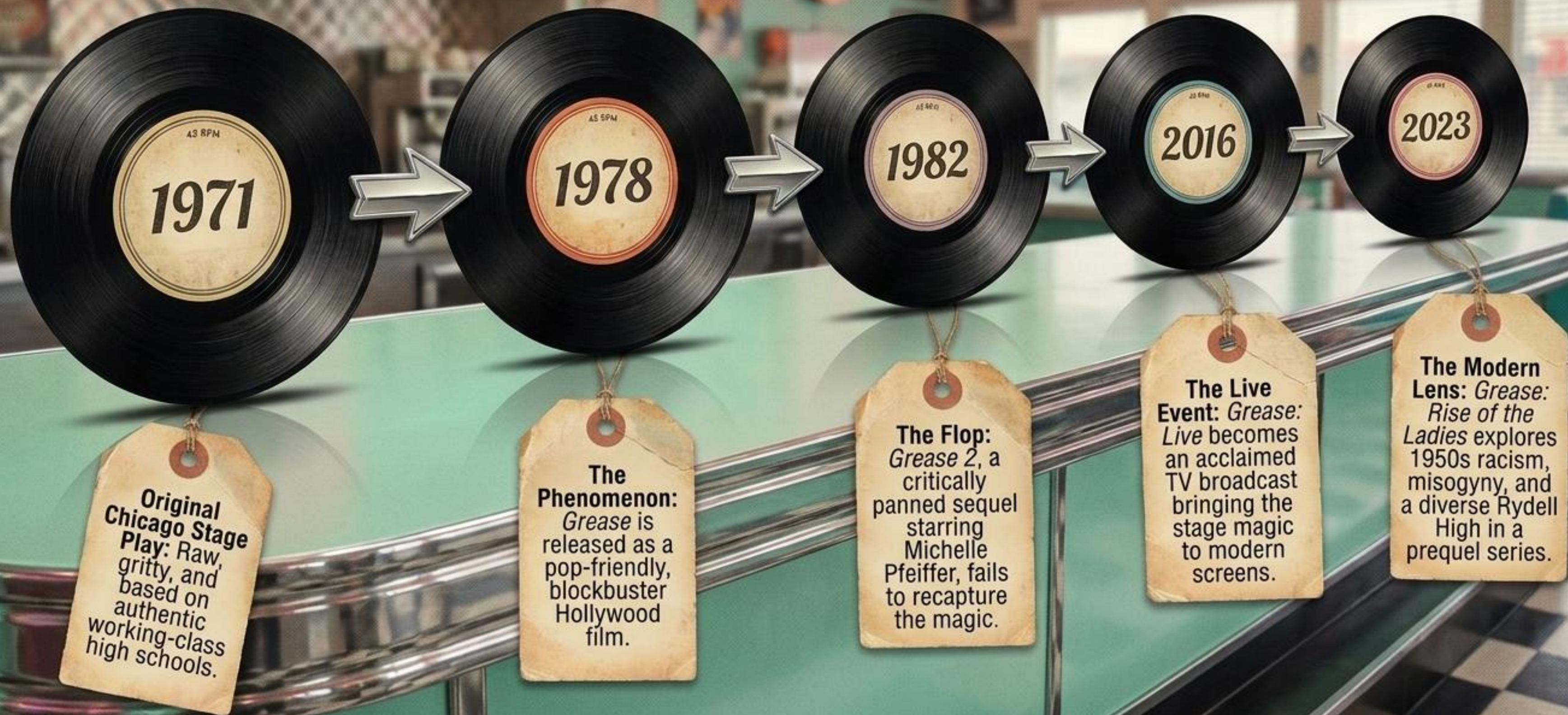
SCORE

2020

The year the film was added to the U.S. National Film Registry by the Library of Congress for its cultural significance.



Grease Through the Years



Modern Reassessment: A 2020s Lens

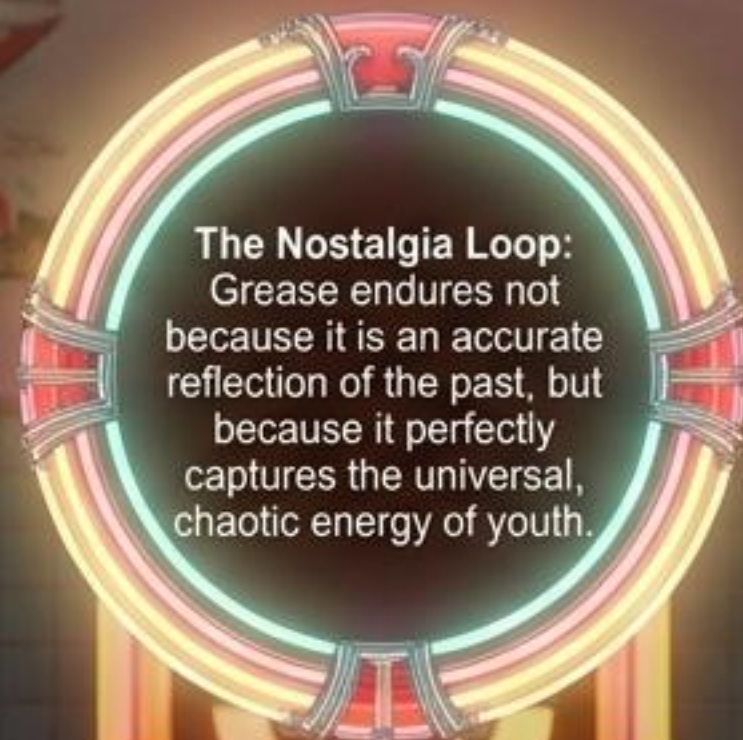
The Nostalgia

- Universally loved, catchy pop-rock music.
- Relatable teenage awkwardness and insecurity.
- Iconic, timeless fashion that inspires Halloween costumes decades later.

The Critique

- Viewed by modern audiences as decidedly un-feminist.
- Features regressive slut-shaming and lacks racial diversity in the 1978 cast.

It isn't horribly sexist and offensive, it's just that its characters say and do horrible, sexist and offensive things... in short, they're a lot like people.



Culture & Conversation: Your Turn



1. Identity & Cliques: Grease features distinct groups like the Pink Ladies and T-Birds. Why do teenagers naturally form these cliques? Does this happen in your culture? - \$1.50



2. Transformation: At the end of the film, Sandy completely changes her appearance and attitude for Danny. Is this an act of empowerment and self-discovery, or giving in to peer pressure? - \$2.25



3. The Power of Nostalgia: The 1970s looked back at the 1950s as a simpler time. Why do people often view the past through rose-colored glasses? What era is your generation nostalgic for? - \$3.00

Thank You! Please Pay Cashier.

Thank You.

**WE GO
TOGETHER.**